

WEEK 9 · AGENCY & RESISTANCE

CLASS 2

Resistance

READING 1

“The Class Significance of School Counter-Culture” in *The Process of Schooling* – Willis

READING 2

Wayward Lives, Beautiful Experiments (interview transcript) – Hartman

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Paul Willis

This new type of school . . . is destined not merely to perpetuate social differences but to crystallize them in Chinese complexities. (Antonio Gramsci on 'democratic' educational reforms in Italy during the early twenties²)

The existence of anti-school cultures in schools with a working-class catchment area has been widely commented upon.³ The raising of the school-leaving age has further dramatized and exposed this culture, often in the form of a 'new' crisis: disruption in the classroom. Teachers' unions are calling more and more vehemently for tougher action against 'violence' in the classroom, and for special provision for the 'unruly' minority. The 'reluctant fifth', difficult 'RSLA classes' and young, 'always in tears' (usually female) teachers, have become part of staffroom folklore.

The welter of comment and response, has, however, served to conceal certain crucial features of this culture: the profound significance it has for processes of job selection, and its relation to the wider working-class culture. In what follows I want to draw attention to these omissions. Concretely I want to make two suggestions. (1) Counter-school culture is part of the wider working-class culture of a region and ultimately of the nation, and, in particular, runs parallel to what we might call shop-floor culture. (2) The located anti-school culture provides powerful informal criteria and binding experiential processes which lead working-class lads to make the 'voluntary' choice to enter the factory, and so to help to reproduce both the existing class structure of employment and the 'culture of the shop floor' as a segment of the overarching working-class culture. My argument is, then, that the stage of affiliation with the counter-school

group carries much more significance than is usually acknowledged. I therefore go on to examine, in the latter part of this chapter, when, how and why this process occurs. I will conclude with some comments on the meaning and status of this general class culture, of which the school and factory variants are part.

Studies of the transition from school to work, which might have made the connection between the school social system and the world of work, have simply been content to register a failure of the agencies and their rational policies—derived basically from middle-class preconceptions. The matrix of inappropriate middle-class logic—self-development, self-knowledge, matching of lifestyle/career profile—overlying the located, informal cultural processes in the institutional practice of the Youth Employment Service and the relentlessly descriptive set of the main writings on the 'transition',⁴ have effectively obscured the essential connectedness of working-class experience for the young male proceeding from school to work. Studies of the school⁵ have been absorbed by the cultural divisions in the school itself, and have, implicitly at any rate, isolated the school from its surrounding networks. Consequently they have failed to address the central question of the determinancy of counter-school culture—is it the institution or the class context, or what mixture of both, which leads to the formation of this culture? In general the omission of the context in which the school operates would seem to imply that the institution be given primacy in the determination of the social landscape of the school.

My own research suggests that there is a direct relationship between the main features of working-class culture, as it is expressed in shop-floor culture, and school counter-culture. Both share broadly the same determinants: the common impulse is to develop strategies for dealing with boredom, blocked opportunities, alienation and lack of control. Of course the particular organization of each located culture has its

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own history and specificity, and worked-up institutional forms. The institution of the school, for instance, determines a particular uneven pattern of extension and suppression of common working-class themes. In one way a more protected environment than the shop floor, and without the hard logic and discipline of material production, the school is nevertheless a more directly face-to-face repressive agency in other ways. This encourages an emphasis on certain obvious forms of resistance specific to the school. In one sense this is simply a question of inverting the given rules—hence the terrain of school counter-culture: smoking, proscribed dress, truancy, cheek in class, vandalism and theft.

At any rate, the main cultural and organizational aspects of shop-floor culture (at least in the Midlands industrial conurbation where I did my research), and for the moment ignoring the range of historically and occupationally specific variants, bear a striking similarity to the main features of school counter-culture. I concentrate here mainly on shop-floor culture, since the other chapters of this volume deal mainly with aspects of school culture.

The really central point about the working-class culture of the shop floor is that, despite harsh conditions and external direction, people do look for meaning and impose frameworks. They exercise their abilities and seek enjoyment in activity, even where most controlled by others. They do, paradoxically, thread through the dead experience of work a living culture which is far from a simple reflex of defeat. This is the same fundamental taking hold of an alienating situation as one finds in counter-school culture and its attempt to weave a tapestry of interest and diversion through the dry institutional text. These cultures are not simply foam paddings, rubber layers between human and unpleasantness. They are appropriations in their own right, exercises of skill, motions, activities applied towards particular ends.

More specifically, the central, locating theme of shop-floor culture—a form of masculine chauvinism arising from the raw experience of production—is reflected in the independence and toughness found in school counter-cultures. Here is a foundry-man talking at home about his work. In an inarticulate way, but for that perhaps all the more convincingly, he attests that elemental, essentially masculine, self-esteem in the doing of a hard job well—and to be known for it.

I work in a foundry . . . you know drop forging . . . do you know anything about it . . . no . . . well you have the factory know the factory down in Bethnall Street with the noise . . . you can hear it in the street . . . I work there on the big hammer . . . it's a six-tonner. I've worked there 24 years now. It's bloody noisy, but I've got used to it now . . . and it's hot I don't get bored . . . there's always new lines coming and you have to work out the best way of doing it . . . You have

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to keep going . . . and it's heavy work, the managers couldn't do it, there's not many strong enough to keep lifting the metal . . . I earn 80, 90 pounds a week, and that's not bad is it? . . . it ain't easy like . . . you can definitely say that I earn every penny of it . . . you have to keep it up you know. And the managing director, I'd say 'hello' to him you know, and the progress manager . . . they'll come around and I'll go . . . 'all right' (thumbs up) . . . and they know you, you know . . . a group standing there watching you . . . working . . . I like that . . . there's something there . . . watching *you* like . . . working . . . like that . . . you have to keep going to get enough out.

Here is Joey, this man's son, in his last year at school, and right at the heart of the counter-culture:

That's it, we've developed certain ways of talking, certain ways of acting and we developed disregards for Pakis, Jamaicans and all different . . . for all the scrubs and the fucking ear—'oles and all that (. . .) There's no chivalry or nothing, none of this cobbles you know, it's just . . . if you'm gonna fight, it's savage fighting anyway, so you might as well go all the way and win it completely by having someone else help ya or by winning the dirtiest methods you can think of like poking his eyes out or biting his ear and things like this.

There's a clear continuity of attitudes here, and we must not think that this distinctive complex of chauvinism, toughness and machismo is anachronistic or bound to die away as the pattern of industrial work changes. Rough, unpleasant, demanding jobs *do* still exist in considerable numbers. A whole range of jobs—from building work, to furnace work to deep sea fishing—still involve a primitive confrontation with exacting physical tasks. The basic attitudes and values developed in such jobs are still very important in general working-class culture, and particularly the culture of the shop floor; this importance is vastly out of proportion to the number of people involved in such heavy work. Even in so-called light industries, or in highly mechanized factories where the awkwardness of the physical task has long since been reduced, the metaphoric figures of strength, masculinity and reputation still move beneath the more varied and richer, visible forms of work-place culture. Despite, even, the increasing numbers of women employed, the most fundamental ethos of the factory is profoundly masculine.

The other main, and this time emergent, theme of shop-floor culture—at least in the manufacturing industries of the Midlands—is the massive attempt to gain a form of control of the work process. 'Systematic soldiering' and 'gold bricking' have been observed from the particular perspective of management from F. W. Taylor⁶ onwards, but there is evidence now of a much more concerted—though still informal—attempt

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to gain control. It does happen, now, sometimes, that the men themselves actually run production. Again this is effectively mirrored for us by working-class kids' attempts, with the resources of their counter-culture, to take control of classes, insert their own unofficial timetables, and control their own routines and life spaces.

Joey: (. .) of a Monday afternoon, we'd have nothing right? Nothing hardly relating to school work, Tuesday afternoon we have swimming and they stick you in a classroom for the rest of the afternoon, Wednesday afternoon you have games and there's only Thursday and Friday afternoon that you work, if you call that work. The last lesson Friday afternoon we used to go and doss, half of us wagged out o' lessons and the other half go into the classroom, sit down and just go to sleep, and the rest of us could join a class where all our mates are.

Will: (. .) What we been doing, playing cards in this room 'cos we can lock the door.

PW: Which room's this now?

Will: Resources Centre, where we're making the frames (*a new stage for the deputy head*), s'posed to be.

PW: Oh! You're still making the frames?

Will: We should have had it finished, we just lie there on top of the frame, playing cards, or trying to get to sleep.

PW: What's the last time you've done some writing?

Will: When we done some writing?

Fuzz: Oh ah, last time was in careers, 'cos I writ 'yes' on a piece of paper, that broke me heart.

PW: Why did it break your heart?

Fuzz: I mean to write, 'cos I was going to try and go through the term without writing anything. 'Cos since we've cum back, I ain't dun nothing. (*It was half-way through term.*)

Put this against the following account from the father of a boy who was in the same friendship group as the boys talking above. He is a factory hand on a track producing car engines, talking at his home.

Actually the foreman, the gaffer, don't run the place, the men run the place. See, I mean you get one of the chaps says, 'Alright, you'm on so and so today.' You can't argue with him. The gaffer don't give you the job, the men on the track give you the job, they swop each other about, tek it in turns. Ah, but I mean the job's done. If the gaffer had gid you the job you would . . . They tried to do it, one morning, gid a chap a job you know, but he'd been on it, you know, I think he'd been on all week, and they just downed tools. (. . .) There's four hard jobs on the track and there's dozens that's, . . you know, a child of five could do it, quite honestly, but everybody has their turn. That's organized by the men.

Of course there is the obvious difference that the school informal organization is devoted to doing nothing, while in the factory culture, at least, 'the job's done'. But the degree of opposition to official authority *in each case* should not be minimized, and production managers in such shops were quite as worried as deputy heads about 'what things were coming to'. Furthermore, both these attempts at control rest on the basic and distinctive unit of the informal group. This is the fundamental unit of resistance in both cultures, which locates and makes possible all its other elements. It is the zone where 'creative' attempts to develop and extend an informal culture are made, and where strategies for resting control of symbolic and real space from official authority are generated and disseminated. It is the massive presence of this informal organization which most decisively marks off shop-floor culture from middle-class cultures of work, and the 'lads' school culture from that of the 'ear-oles' (the name used by the 'lads' of my research to designate those who conformed to the school's official culture).

The solidarity, and sense of being 'in the group', is the basis for the final major characteristic of shop-floor culture that I want to describe here. This is the distinctive form of language, and the highly developed humour of the shop floor. Up to half the verbal exchanges are not serious or about work activities. They are jokes, or 'piss-takes', or 'kiddings' or 'wind-ups'. There is a real skill in being able to use this language with fluency: to identify the points where you are being 'kidded' and to have appropriate response in order to avoid further baiting.

This badinage is necessarily difficult to record on tape or represent, but the highly distinctive ambience it gives to shop floor exchanges is widely recognized by those involved, and to some extent re-created in their accounts of it. This is a foundry-worker talking at home about the atmosphere in his shop:

Oh, there's all sorts, millions of them (*jokes*). 'Want to hear what he said about you', and he never said a thing, you know. Course you know the language, at the work like. 'What you been saying, about me'; 'I said nothing', 'Oh you're a bloody liar', and all this.

Associated with this concrete and expressive verbal humour is a developed physical humour; essentially the practical joke. These jokes are vigorous, sharp, sometimes cruel, and often hinge on prime tenets of the culture such as disruption of production or subversion of the bosses' authority and status. Here is the same man:

They er'm play jokes on you, blokes knocking the clamps off the boxes, they put paste on the bottom of his hammer you know soft little thing, puts his hammer down, picks it up, gets a handful of paste, you know, all this. So he comes up and gets a syringe and throws it in the big bucket of

paste, and it's about that deep, and it goes right to the bottom, you have to put your hand in and get it out (. . .) This is a filthy trick, but they do it. (. . .) They asked, the gaffers asked—to make the tea. Well it's fifteen years he's been there and they say 'go and make the teas'. He gus up the toilet, he wets in the tea pot, then makes the tea. I mean, you know, this is the truth this is you know. He says, you know, 'I'll piss in it if I mek it, if they've asked me to mek it.' (. . .) so he goes up, wees in the pot, then he puts the tea bag, then he puts the hot water in. (. . .)—was bad the next morning, one of the gaffers, 'My stomach isn't half upset this morning.' He told them after and they called him for everything, 'you ain't makin' our tea no more,' he says. 'I know I ain't not now.'

This atmosphere of rough humour and horseplay is instantly recognizable among the 'lads' in working-class schools, and obviously missing from the more hesitant 'polite' exchanges amongst the 'ear-'oles'. The ethnography of school cultures is full of similar—virtually interchangeable—incidents. There is the same felt desire to brighten grey prospects with a 'larf'. Certainly for the group of 'lads' who were the focus of my 'main' case study, reliance on the group, verbal humour and physical trickery, was the continuous stuff of their informal relations.

Joey: You know you have to come to school today, if you're feeling bad, your mate'll soon cheer yer up like, 'cos you couldn't go without ten minutes in this school, without having a laugh at something or other.

PW: Are your mates a really big important thing at school now?

—Yeah

—Yeah

—Yeah

Joey: They're about the best thing actually.

Spanksey: You like to come to school, just to skive, 'cos you get bored at home. You'd rather come here and sit in the Youth Wing or summat.

Joey: (. . .) You'm always looking out on somebody (*when skiving*) and you've always got something to talk about, . . . something.

PW: So what stops you being bored?

Joey: Talking, we could talk for ever, when we get together, it's talk, talk, talk.

There is no space to pursue the point any further, but in more detailed ways, from theft, vandalism and sabotage to girlie books under the tool-bench or desk, it is apparent that shop-floor culture and school oppositional culture have a great deal in common.

The parallelism of these cultures suggests, of course, that they should both be thought of as aspects of the larger working-class culture, though a fuller account would obviously further differentiate regional, occupational and institutional variations. The fundamental point here is to stress that anti-school culture should

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be seen in the context of this larger pattern, rather than in simple institutional terms. This wider connection has important and unexamined implications for the school's management of the 'disruptive' minority. Put at its most obvious, strategies conceived at the institutional level will not overcome problems arising from a profound class-cultural level. In fact the concerned teacher may be effectively boxed in, since the undoubted level of institutional determinacy—which I am not denying—may well block those strategies which do take into account the wider working-class culture. I mean that the teacher who tries to use working-class themes or styles may be rejected because he's a teacher: 'there's nothing worse than a teacher trying to be too friendly', and that a teacher who innovates organizationally—destreaming, mixed ability groupings, etc.—can never prevent the emergence of oppositional working-class themes *in one form or another*. It is the peculiarly intractable nature of this double determinacy which makes this form of working-class culture present itself as a 'crisis'. It shows up in high relief some of the unintended consequences and contradictions inherent in the state's ever-expanding attempts to make inroads into located working-class culture.

I do not wish, here, to go into the complex questions concerning what makes working-class culture—in all its variety and sectionalism—what it is. Nor—having, I hope, established the similarity between shop-floor and anti-school culture—do I want to claim any simple causation between them. My aims are more limited; my immediate text is that of job choice among working-class lads. What I want to argue about the parallelism I have described is that it accomplishes—in practice—a continuity between the two cultures, between work and school, in terms of the experiential passage of the working-class individual and his group. Processes within the school culture generate unofficial and deeply influential criteria which guide kids to similar, though expanded, situations: i.e. the shop floor. These unofficial criteria make a much more compelling case for particular job choices than does any amount of formal guidance.

Before looking at these located criteria, though, let us look at the manner in which the counter-school culture blocks, or reinterprets, the formal information concerning work with which it is saturated. All official communications about careers and work are importantly filtered through the group. By and large what might be termed as the *denoted*⁷ messages from teachers and careers officers are most heavily filtered. This is the manifest content of particular communications concerning either the practical details of specific jobs or general principles about the best form of approach to work. Unless an individual has already decided to do a certain specific job, information about it is simply not taken in. It is certainly not true that new information is fed into a rational grid system which matches job profile with ability profile, or lifestyle/with/job/ambition profile. If things are remembered, they are

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picked up by some highly selective living principle of the counter-cultural school group. The following discussion is on careers films:

Perc: I wonder why there's never kids like us in films, see what their attitude is to it? What they'm like and what we'm like.

PW: Well, what sort of kids are they in the films?

Fuzz: All ear-'oles.

Perc: All goody-goodyes.

Will: No, you can tell they've been told what to say. They'm probably at some acting school or summat y'know and the opportunity to do this job—film careers for other kids—and you gotta say this, 'Wait for your cue', 'Wait till he's finished his lines.'

Information that is given to the kids concerning what might be thought of as an ideology of getting a job, and of getting on in a job, is either blocked, interpreted into unrecognizable forms or simply inverted. The following conversation is from a discussion on careers sessions:

Spanksey: After a bit you tek no notice of him, he sez the same thing over and over again, you know what I mean?

Joey: We're always too busy fucking picking your nose, or flicking paper, we just don't listen to him.

PW: How about the speaker who came from the College of Education?

Fred: They try to put you off work . . . Joey, he says to him, 'Do you want to be a painter and decorator, painting a wall, you can get any silly cunt to paint a wall', or 'Do you want to do the decorative pieces, sign writing.'

Spanksey: Got to be someone in society who slops on a wall . . . I wanted to get up and say to him, 'There's got to be some silly cunt who slops on a wall.'

In terms of actual 'job choice', it is the 'lads' culture and not the official careers material which provides the most located and deeply influential guides for the future. For the individual's affiliation with the non-conformist group carries with it a whole range of changes in his attitudes and perspectives and these changes also supply over time a more or less consistent view of what sorts of people he wants to end up working with, and what sort of situation is going to allow the fullest expression for his developing cultural skills. The located 'lads' culture supplies a set of 'unofficial' criteria by which to judge not individual jobs or the intrinsic joys of particular kinds of work—indeed it is already assumed that all work is more or less hard and unrewarding—but generally *what kind* of working situation is going to be most relevant to the individual. It will have to be work where he can be open about his desires, his sexual feelings, his liking for 'booze' and his aim to 'skive off' as much as is reasonably possible. It will have to be a place where

people can be trusted and will not 'creep off' to tell the boss about 'foreigners' or 'nicking stuff'—precisely where there were the fewest 'ear-'oles'. Indeed it would have to be work where there was a boss, a 'them and us', which always carried with it the danger of treacherous intermediaries. The experience of the division 'ear-'ole'/'lads' in school is one of the most basic preparations for the still ubiquitous feeling in the working class proper that there is a 'them' and an 'us'. The 'us' is felt to be relatively weaker in power terms, but also somehow more approachable, social, and, in the end, more human. One of the really crucial things about the 'us' which the 'lads' wanted to be part of was that they were in work where the self could be separated from the work task, and value given to people for things other than their work performance—the celebration of those independent qualities which precisely the 'ear-'oles' did not have. Generally, the future work situation would have to be one where people were not 'cissies' and could handle themselves, where 'pen-pushing' is looked down on in favour of really 'doing things'. It would have to be a situation where you could speak up for yourself, and where you would not be expected to be subservient. The particular job would have to pay good money fairly quickly and offer the possibility of 'fiddles' and 'perks' to support already acquired smoking and drinking habits. Work would have to be a place, most basically, where people were 'all right' and with whom a general culture identity could be shared. It is this human face of work, much more than its intrinsic or technical nature, which confronts the individual as the crucial dimension of his future. In the end it is recognized that it is specifically the cultural diversion that makes any job bearable. Talking about the imminent prospect of work:

Will: I'm just dreading the first day like. Y'know, who to pal up with, an er'm, who's the ear-'oles, who'll tell the gaffer.

Joey: (. . .) you can always mek it enjoyable. It's only you what makes a job unpleasant, . . . I mean if you're cleaning sewers out, you can have your moments like. Not every job's enjoyable, I should think. Nobody's got a job they like unless they're a comedian or something, but er'm . . . , no job's enjoyable 'cos of the fact that you've got to get up of a morning and go out when you could stop in bed. I think every job's got, has a degree of unpleasantness, but it's up to you to mek . . . to push that unpleasantness aside and mek it as good and as pleasant as possible.

The typical division in school between the 'lads' and the 'ear-'oles' also has a profound influence on thoughts about work. It is also a division between different kinds of future, different kinds of gratification and different kinds of job that are relevant to these things. These differences, moreover, are not random or unconnected. On the one hand they arise

systematically from intra-school group oppositions and, on the other, they relate to quite distinct job groupings in the *post-school* situation. The 'ear-'oles'/ 'boys' division becomes the skilled/unskilled and white-collar/blue-collar division. The 'lads' themselves could transpose the divisions of the internal cultural landscape of the school on to the future, and on to the world of work outside, with considerable clarity. Talking about 'ear-'oles':

Joey: I think they're (*the 'ear-'oles'*) the ones that have got the proper view of life, they're the ones that abide by the rules. They're the civil servant types, they'll have 'ouses and everything before us (. . .) They'll be the toffs, I'll say they'll be the civil servants, toffs, and we'll be the brickies and things like that.

Spanksey: I think that we . . . , more or less, we're the ones that do the hard grafting but not them, they'll be the office workers. (. . .) I ain't got no ambitions, I doe wanna have . . . I just want to have a nice wage, that 'ud just see me through.

Not only does the 'lads' culture and its opposition to conformism provide criteria for the kind of job which is relevant to them, it also possesses internal mechanisms—the 'kidding', the 'piss-take', the 'larf'—to enforce a certain view of appropriate work. In a discussion on what jobs they wanted:

Eddie: I wanna be a jeweller.

PW: A what?
/Laughter/

Eddie: A jeweller.

PW: I dunno, what's the joke. What's funny about a jeweller.
/Laughter/
—he's a cunt.
—he's a piss-taker.
—'im, he, he'd nick half of the jewels he would.

Spike: He wants to be a diamond-setter in six months.

Derek: He'd put one in a ring and six in his pocket.

PW: Do you know anything about jewellery?

Eddie: No.
/Laughter/

Altogether, in relation to the basic cultural ground-shift which is occurring, and the development of a comprehensive alternative view of what is expected from life, *particular* job choice does not matter too much to the 'lads'. Indeed we may see that, with respect to the criteria this located culture throws up, most manual and semi-skilled jobs *are* the same and it would be a waste of time to use the provided middle-class grids across them to find material differences. Considered, therefore, in just one quantum of time—the last months of school—individual job choice does indeed seem random and unenlightened by any rational techniques or end/means schemes. It is,

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however, confusing and mystifying to pose the entry of working-class youth into work as a matter of *particular* job choice—this is, in essence, a very middle-class construct. The criteria we have looked at, the opposition to other more conformist views of work, and the solidarity of the group process, all transpose the question of job choice on to another plane: these lads are not choosing careers or particular jobs, they are committing themselves to a future of generalized labour. Even if it's not explicitly verbalized, from the way many of the kids actually get jobs and their calm expectation that their jobs will change a lot, they do not basically make much differentiation between jobs—it's *all labour*. In a discussion on the jobs they had arranged for when they left:

Perc: I was with my mate, John's brother, I went with 'im to er, . . . he wanted a job. Well, John's sister's boyfriend got a job at this place, and he sez to Allan, he sez, 'Go down there and they might give you a job there', and he went down, and they sez, 'You're too old for training', 'cos he's twenty now, he sez to Allan, he sez, 'Who's that out there', and he sez, 'One of me mates', he sez, 'does he wanna job', and he sez, 'I dunno.' He sez er'm, 'Ask him.' He comes out, I went back in and he told me about it and he sez, 'Come back before you leave if you want it.'
—: What you doing?

Perc: Carpentry, joining. And a month ago I went back and, well, not a month ago, a few weeks ago and I seen him.

PW: Well, that was a complete accident really. I mean had you been thinking of joinery?

Perc: Well, you've only got to go and see me woodwork, I've had it, I ain't done woodwork for years.

In a discussion of their future:

Eddie: I don't think any of us'll have one job and then stick to it, none of us. We'll swop around.

Spike: It just shows in your part-time jobs don't it, don't stick to a part-time job.

Shop-floor culture has, as we have seen, an objective dimension which gives it a certain strength and power. Now this quality chimes—unexpectedly for some—with the criteria for acceptable work already thrown up by the counter-school culture. The young adult, therefore, impelled towards the shop floor, shares much more than he knows with his own future. When the lad reaches the factory there is no shock, only recognition. He is likely to have had experience anyway of work through part-time jobs, and he is immediately familiar with many of the shop-floor practices: defeating boredom, time-wasting, heavy and physical humour, petty theft, 'fiddling', 'handling yourself'.

There is a further, perhaps less obvious, way in which the working-class boy who is from the 'lads' is

drawn in to the factory and confirmed in his choice. This is in the likely response of his new employer to what he understands of the 'lads' culture already generated at school. The reverse side of the 'them' and 'us' attitude of the 'lads' is an acceptance by them of prior authority relations. Although directly and apparently geared to make some cultural interest and capital out of an unpleasant situation, it also accomplishes a recognition of, and an accommodation to, the facts of power and hierarchy. In the moment of the establishment of a cultural opposition is the yielding of a hope for direct, or quasi-political, challenge. The 'them' and 'us' philosophy is simultaneously a rescue and confirmation of the direct, the human and the social, and a giving up—at any conscious level—of claims to control the under-workings of these things: the real power relationships. This fact is of central importance in understanding the peculiar density and richness, as well as the limitedness and frequent short-sightedness, of counter-school and shop-floor culture.

Now, curiously enough, those conformist lads who enter the factory unaided by cultural supports, diversions and typical, habituated patterns of interpretation can be identified by those in authority as more threatening and less willing to accept the established *status quo*. For these lads still believe, as it were, the rubric of equality, advance through merit and individualism which the school, in its anodyne way, has more or less unproblematically passed on to them. Thus, although there is no surface opposition, no insolent style to enrage the conventional onlooker, there is also no secret pact, made in the reflex moment of an oppositional style, to accept a timeless authority structure: a timeless 'us' and 'them'. Consequently, these kids are more likely to *expect real* satisfaction from their work; to expect the possibility of advance through hard work; to expect authority relations, in the end, to reflect only differences in competence. All these expectations, coupled frequently with a real unhappiness in the individual unrelieved by a social diversion, make the conformist lad very irksome and 'hard to deal with'. In manual and semi-skilled jobs, then, those in authority often actively prefer the 'lads' type to the 'ear-'ole' type. Underneath the 'roughness' of the 'lads' is a realistic assessment of their position, an ability to get on with others to make the day *and production* pass, and a lack of 'pushiness' about their job and their future in it. Finally, the 'lads' are more likeable because they have 'something to say for themselves', and will 'stand up for themselves', but only in a restricted mode which falls short of one of the 'us' wanting to join the 'them'. It is precisely this parlous ground upon which the conformist often unwittingly and unhappily stands. For one of the 'lads', not only is the shop floor more familiar than he might expect, but he is also welcomed and accepted by his new superiors in such a way that seems to allow for the expression of his own personality where the school had been precisely trying to block it—this is an

initial confirming response which further marks up the 'transition' from school as a liberation.

What is surprising in this general process of induction into the factory is the voluntary—almost celebratory—nature of the 'lads' choice. The recognition of themselves in a future of industrial work is not a question of defeat, coercion or resignation. Nor is it simply the result of a managed, machiavellian process of social control. It is a question, at any rate in part and at least at this age, of an affiliation which is seen as joyous, creative and attractive. This fact is of enormous importance to us in understanding the true complexity of the reproduction of our social order: there is an element of 'self-damnation' in the acceptance of subordinate roles.

It is the partly autonomous functioning of the processes we have been considering which surprisingly accomplishes the most difficult task of state schooling: to 'direct' a proportion of kids to the unrewarding and basic tasks of industrial production. The word 'direct' is carefully chosen here since it need not have connotations of coercion, but it does make the unequivocal of the destination clear.

Pierre Bourdieu⁸ argues that it is the exclusive 'cultural capital'—among other things, skill in the symbolic manipulation of language and figures—of the dominant groups in society which ensures the success of their offspring and so the reproduction of their class privilege. This is because educational advancement is controlled through the 'fair' meritocratic testing of precisely these skills which 'cultural capital' provides. We can make a bleak inversion of this hypothesis and suggest that it is the partly 'autonomous' counter-cultures of the working class at the site of the school which 'behind the back' of official policy ensure the continuity of its own under-privilege through the process we have just been considering. This process achieves the reproduction of underprivilege much more systematically than could any *directed* state policy. Of course state policy *says* it is doing the opposite. In this case, then, 'autonomous' working-class processes achieve the 'voluntary' reproduction of their own conditions *in spite of* state policy. We cannot unravel this complex knot here, save to observe that the widespread *belief* in the egalitarianism of state policy—not least among teachers themselves—may be an essential prerequisite for the continual functioning of those *actual* processes which are working to the opposite effect.⁹

We have looked at aspects of the process whereby some typical working-class kids come to regard their future in the factory as natural, inevitable, and even freely chosen. We have seen the pivotal importance of the 'lads' counter-school culture in this process. Analytically, therefore, the most basic parameter in terms of so-called 'job choice' is affiliation or non-affiliation with this group, rather than the more or less random (correctly recorded in the major studies) influences—official and other—operating during the specific period of the actual passage from school to

work. From my own work it is perfectly clear that this affiliation with the counter-school group can happen at any time from the second year onwards. I want to term this important process of affiliation *differentiation*: the separation of self from a pre-given system.¹⁰

Even where there had been some form of social division in the junior school—and there is plenty of evidence in ‘ragging of teacher’s pets’, that there was,—in the first years of the secondary school everyone, it seems, is an ‘ear-’ole’. Even the few of those who come to the school with a developed delinquent eye for the social landscape behave in a conformist way because of the lack of any visible support group. On ‘coming out’ as a ‘lad’:

Spike: In the first year . . . I could spot the ‘ear-’oles’. I knew who the fucking high boys was, just looking at ‘em walking around the playground—first day I was there (. . .) I was just, was just quiet for the first two weeks, I just kept meself to meself like, not knowing anybody, it took me two years to get in with a few mates. But, er . . . after that, the third years was a right fucking year, fights, having to go to teachers a lot.

Still, whether the process is resumed or starts from afresh in later years, what can we understand of its elements and nature? Basically I suggest that we should understand *differentiation* not as some quality or change within the individual but as a *change in the relationship*—at a greater or lesser speed—between staff and pupils. The founding relationship between teacher and pupil in our society, and one which can endure for the entire pupil career of some individuals, is of superior/inferior established in the axis of institutionally-defined qualities—knowledge, development, effort, probity—and on the destruction, suppression or suspension of ‘private’ or ‘other’ axes of knowledge and control. This is something of an ideal type, and has been hardened here for the sake of clarity. Certainly some reformists might argue that there is more now allowed under the school roof than a conventional model of this type. Be that as it may, in terms of how schools are *actually* run in working-class areas, and certainly the ones I saw, this axial definition gives us the most useful paradigm for understanding actual behaviour. In a very obvious sense, despite much vaunted curriculum reform, teachers control what is taught in classes—most certainly in the early school years. This model, and especially what it tells us about the attitude to privacy, becomes most valuable, however, when we come to look at face-to-face relationships—and remember that the school is the agency of face-to-face control *par excellence*. The stern look of the inquiring teacher; the relentless pursuit of ‘the truth’ set up as a value even above good behaviour; the common weapon of ridicule; the accepted arrangements for tears after a caning; the stereotypical deputy head, body poised, head lowered, finger jabbing the culprit; the un-

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expected head bearing down on a group in the corridor: ‘Where’s your tie, think you own this place?’ are all tactics for exposing and destroying, or freezing the private. What successful conventional teaching cannot tolerate is private reservation. And in the early forms in virtually any school it’s plain to see that most kids are reciprocating in this relationship. The eager first-form hands reaching and snapping to answer first are all seeking approval from an acknowledged superior in a very particular institutional form. And in the *individual* competition for approval, the possibility of private reservations becoming *shared* to form any oppositional definition of the situation is decisively controlled. The teacher is given formal control of his pupils by the state, but unless he can exert his social control through an *educational* paradigm, his position would become merely that of the prison guard.

For the members of the ‘lads’ culture, of course, that is exactly how the teachers are seen and, for the teacher, the change in relationship this implies makes his situation increasingly untenable and one of survival rather than of education. *Differentiation* is where the teacher’s superiority is denied because the mode in which that superiority is expressed is delegitimated—there are *other* ways of valuing oneself. This valuation comes from those ‘private’ areas, *now shared* and made visible, which were held in check before. These resources are mobilized to penetrate the nature of the teacher’s previous authority and to develop forms of resistance. The following is a classic statement—albeit exaggerated—of an attempt by a teacher to act against the ‘private’ or ‘independent’ area of the pupil’s life, and of a resistance born of an essential belief that the teacher’s authority is arbitrary, and predicated on an illegitimate suppression of other meanings and activities. In a discussion on teachers:

Joey: (. . .) the way we’re subject to their every whim like. They want something doing and we have to sort of do it, ‘cos, er, . . . er, we’re just, ‘cos, er . . . , we’re under them like. We were with a woman teacher in here, and ‘cos we all wear rings and one or two of them bangles, like he’s got one on, and out of the blue, like, for no special reason, she says, ‘Take all that off.’

PW: Really?

Joey: Yeah, we says, ‘One won’t come off’, she says, ‘Take yours off as well.’ I said, ‘You’ll have to chop my finger off first.’

PW: Why did she want you to take your rings off?

Joey: Just a sort of show like. Teachers do this, like, all of a sudden they’ll make you do your ties up and things like this. You’re subject to their every whim like. If they want something done, if you don’t think it’s right, and you object against it, you’re down to Simmondsey (*the head*), or you get the cane, you get some extra work tonight.

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And of course once this pupil analysis develops it soon moves off from a defensive resistance to an offensive one.

Joey: It's a sort of a challenge, coming to school thinking, 'How can I outwit the teachers today?', like. The teachers're the establishment, they've done things to you, you don't like what they've done, how can you get back?

During this period of *differentiation* and after, one really decisive way of blocking the teacher's attempts to penetrate that which is private and informal is to be 'ignorant': to be uninterested in what the teacher has to offer. In a system where knowledge, and the educational paradigm, are used as a form of social control, 'ignorance' can be used in the same way as a barrier to control. The traditional notions of the causality of counter-school culture in low (measured) intelligence would, perhaps, be better reversed.

If the conventional paradigm of the teaching relationship is expressed powerfully in face-to-face situations, so is the differentiated resistance of the 'lads'. There is a particular overall style which communicates quite clearly to any teacher that 'this guy is not going to be pushed about'. It's a surly, disdainful look; a way of standing in the corridor as an obstruction though it could never be proved; a foot-dragging walk; an over-friendly hello; an attention on ties, fingers, shoes, books, anything rather than the inquiring eyes of the teacher which might penetrate too far.

For those involved the process of becoming a 'lad', is seen as a definite step towards maturity; it's 'coming out of your shell' or 'losing your timidity'. Diligence, deference, respect—these become things which can be read in quite another way.

PW: Evans (*the careers master*) said you were all being very rude, (. . .) you didn't have the politeness to listen to the speaker (*during a careers session*). He said why didn't you realize that you were just making the world very rude for when you grow up and God help you when you have kids 'cos they're going to be worse. What did you think of that?

Joey: They wouldn't. They'll be outspoken. They wouldn't be submissive fucking twits. They'll be outspoken, upstanding sort of people.

Spanksey: If any of my kids are like this, here, I'll be pleased.

That area which I have called 'private' or the 'independent', which the teaching relationship attempts to suppress and which *differentiation* liberates, is, of course, the input to the school social system which derives most clearly from the outside. Fairly obviously, in a working-class area it derives from the working-class culture of the neighbourhood. In the accounts of the boys in the crucial period of affiliation with the 'lads', the external (to the school) content of their experience is evident. Often physically outside of the

school, these incidents also draw on codes of conformism to delinquent or oppositional values which are not those of the school.

Spike: I'll tell you how it first started. It was Joey, Bill, Fred and Farmer (*all from his year at school*), they come round for me and I was . . . never been out with them and I was fucking shittin' meself. I was scared I was. I was only twelve or thirteen. Joey picked a crate of bottles up, threw a bottle to each of us, and said, 'throw 'em' and we fucking threw 'em and Joey threw the crate and it led from there to throwing bricks into train windows, dropping fucking big boulders on to trains, running from the screws, smoking. The reason I say this smoking was to be big. I thought 'Oh, fucking hell, I'm thirteen, here I am, y'know, great, fucking smoking.'

Bill: We all got together and started knocking about and realized that we got to go up a bit like, you know, we started to grow up a bit, bit more sensible things you know . . ., the third-years was the main, the main year for us, when all the Crombies, and all the Skinheads all started really, and we used to knock about together up the (*name of a football ground*).

It will readily be seen that there is a huge reservoir of located cultural meanings and possibilities for experience on the streets open to the 'lads' which is fundamentally working class. This is the basic material which fuels the growing 'private' and 'independent' sector of school experience. Understanding something of how these working-class materials are taken up in the school, and into relationships with teachers, it can be seen that counter-school culture is a particular, worked-up, form of working-class culture taking on specific appearances at the institutional level. We have, in the school counter-culture, a classic case of the circle of entanglements which can occur between state institutions and a situated class.

The very typical bottle-smashing incident described above cannot reasonably be thought of as a *determining* instance of allegiance to counter-school culture. Rather it should be thought of as a *crystallization* of a basic shift in attitudes and loyalties. The boys, themselves, very rarely identify for us any deep causes for the changes they describe so vividly. Apparently, for them, it really is a question of *accidental* causality—sitting by so-and-so in class, meeting 'the lads' at night by chance or being 'called for' unexpectedly. Of course what these accounts do testify to is the importance of the group, and the sense in which, for particular individuals, the group always seems to have been in existence. It is very clearly the strength and presence of the group which allows the 'private' and previously reserved areas within the individual to be expressed and become public.

Attempts to uncover the basic determinants of school counter-culture are fraught with difficulties. It is here that we skirt the deep waters of the determinacy

of basic class cultures. Certainly we should be wary of simplified causal explanations. We can, however, suggest some of the possible factors which first break the individual from the mould of the conventional teacher/pupil paradigm—and once opposition is born it is amplified through group processes and staff reaction, and ultimately becomes self-justifying.

Though it is only rarely verbalized, and though it is finally expressed only at the level of action and cultural involvement, we can discern at the heart of the ‘lads’ culture a fundamental assessment of the real conditions facing them. At some basic level they weigh up and compare the likely outcomes of the possibilities facing them. Now since many of the boys involved enjoy a considerable native intelligence, we cannot assume that the outcome of taking the ‘conformist road’ is reckoned to be academic failure and obloquy. There is, therefore, at some level, an estimation of how even the *successful* outcome of the ‘conformist road’—CSE, perhaps GCE passes and an office job—measures up to the results of taking the ‘non-conformist road’—independence, social collectivity, celebration of direct experience. In one way these are, of course, the obvious and immediate pay-offs, the ‘instant’ as against ‘deferred’ gratifications. It *seems to be* these interests, as such, which win the day. In a discussion on ‘ear-’oles’:

Joey: (. . .) We wanna live for now, wanna live while we’re young, want money to go out with, wanna go with women now, wanna have cars now, and er’m think about five, ten fifteen years’ time when it comes, but other people, say people like the ‘ear-’oles’, they’m getting their exams, they’m working, having no social life, having no fun, and they’re waiting for fifteen years’ time when they’re people, when they’ve got married and things like that. I think that’s the difference. We are thinking about now, and having a larf now, and they’re thinking about the future and the time that’ll be best for ‘em.

However, I want to argue that this is not the thick-headed animal choice for the nearest bale of hay but the result of a collective and individual cultural process of some maturity which takes a sensible wager on the meaning and pay-offs of *several* possibilities over time.¹¹ The possibility of reaching up to the highest strata of employment through the school system as it confronts them in the working-class area seems to be so remote as to be meaningless.¹² The route of *relative* success—an office job—through conformism is more possible. Such an achievement, however, is viewed in a very ambivalent light. The ‘real world’, they felt in their bones, was not quite like the school account of it. The institution might give you a few CSEs but what did that matter if you were an ‘ear-’ole’. ‘Immediate gratification’ might be the basis for the development of highly necessary *long-term* skills. It does not pay to be too ‘timid’ in the strange, modern, industrial metropolis. In a discussion of ‘ear-’oles’:

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Spike: Well, they’ve got no push, I tell yer. Jones, Percival, or . . ., they’ve got nothing inside ‘em to get up there, (. . .) If they’ve got nothing inside ‘em—no spunk to give ‘em the push—they’ve gotta have somebody behind ‘em to push ‘em all the time, and that’s no good. You can’t survive like that.

In a specifically *cultural* mode, then, I am suggesting that the ‘lads’ make some basic assessment of their situation: most obviously of where their *immediate* interests lie, but also of the distinction between ‘how things really work’ and how the state institution of the school says they work;¹³ of how actually to survive in the society which *they know*. Their own analysis is, in many ways, superior to that given to them by their teachers, and it clearly exerts a determining pressure upon the extent of allegiance to the ‘lads’.

Another more obvious determining factor on this allegiance is the influence of parents. Involved in some form of shop-floor culture themselves, it is hardly surprising that their attitudes help to influence the behaviour of their offspring. Certainly for the ‘lads’ there is a widespread sense that their behaviour, in particular their opposition to the school and scorn of the weak and conformist, fits into a larger pattern, is expected of them in some way, and is part of an alternative pattern of being supported and protected by their parents against more official views; much in the way that they collectively supported their own alternative culture against the pressure of the school. In a discussion on ‘ear-’oles’:

Spanksey: (. . .) you know, he ain’t a mastermind (*his dad*) you know. He was a ruffian when he was younger you know, he’s a larf you know. I couldn’t. I don’t think he’d like to see me, his kids, you know, me or our Barry or me little sister, ear-’oles, you know what I mean.

Will: Yeah, and with me, our old man, he was brainy like, but soon as he left school, started to work at the brewery, used to get the booze down him like you know I dare say, that influenced me.

Spanksey: What’s that school on the way to the football Petty Coat Lane, something like that, that was a real rough school that was, in our dad’s time, you know what I mean, and he’s rough.

At the institutional level, it’s also possible to suggest a possibility for how the *process* described above is initiated. In what might be called an act of ‘cultural prolepsis’, staff often put kids into a double-bind situation which can be broken only by fulfilling the *worst* expectations of the teacher. Often the teacher upsets his own conventional teaching paradigm by assuming *too early* that particular groups or individuals reject his superiority and the standards by which it is maintained—and who can grudge him this cultural assumption, faced with what has happened massively in the past? This means, however, that the

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pupil is presented with a goal which he is simultaneously told he can never reach. This is a very characteristic attitude of teachers towards kids on the edge of, or heading towards, or even actually in, counter-school culture: to make exhortations for behaviour of which it is denied the recipient is capable. In a discussion on recent urges by the staff:

Derek: (. . .) They say you'm adults and that and yet, some things they, they'll say you're adults and then they'll say you'm responsible and all this, and then the next thing they'll turn around and say er, 'Walk down the corridor quietly in a line' and they'll treat us like children.

Since, apparently, it's impossible to be good, why not, at least, enjoy the devil's tunes.

The preceding has over-neatly divided the two categories of conformist and non-conformist. Any living school year is a complex mixture of individuals somewhere between these two points. Furthermore, it is also true that staff do not necessarily rate very conformist behaviour highly. Their own institutional axis of approved values registers a certain kind of obedience as 'girlishness', so that they often see a watered-down 'lads' influence in a positive light. Certainly, there is a very important zone between the 'ear-oles' and the 'lads' not dealt with in this paper, where the staff are able to control a certain independence, with its roots in the 'lads' culture by the exercise of curriculum areas and practices which include elements of both the conventional teaching paradigm and the oppositional culture. Sport is the obvious example here, and the following extract comes from a boy who is precisely on this middle ground.

If it was true I wouldn't mind admitting I was an ear-ole, but I think I come somewhere in between . . . I suppose in the first year I was a bit of an ear-ole, you know, and, like more, I've got on with the sports teachers, because I enjoy me sport and I've progressed, because I don't mind having a joke. I don't take it too serious but sometimes I crack a joke about the teachers, you know to their face sort of thing, and they see the funny side of it all. They don't seem to have relationship like that with the ear-oles. They teach 'em, nice, good lads. They seem to treat me as somebody to talk to like.

I have been stressing the 'cultural level' and the way in which 'semi-autonomous' processes at this level have profoundly important material outcomes. In order to do this I have necessarily emphasized the 'creative', independent and even joyous aspects of working-class culture as it is, anyway, for the 'lads' during the 'transition'—they may well have different views a few years into work. Certainly we need to posit the attractiveness of this culture to avoid simple determinist and economist views of what makes kids go to the factory, and to establish properly the level

of the 'voluntarism' by which these lads go to a future that most would account an impoverished one. However, we should be careful not to lionize or romanticize our concept of working-class culture. School counter-culture and shop-floor culture are fundamentally limited and stop well short of providing any fully worked-out future which is an alternative to the one they oppose. Indeed, in certain fundamental respects, we are presented with the contradiction that they actually—in the end—*do the work of bringing about the future that others have mapped for them*. The basic shortcoming of these cultures is that they have failed to convert *symbolic* power into *real* power. The real power thus still creates the most basic channels along which symbolic meanings run so that the symbolic power is used, in the end, to close the circle the *actual* power has opened up, and so finally to *reinforce* the real power relationships. The insistence of a human meaning which must justify its situation, but which does not have the *material* force to change its situation, can simply operate all too easily to legitimate, *experientially*, a situation which is fundamentally alien to it. To put it more concretely, the school counter-culture, for all its independence, accomplishes the induction of manpower 'voluntarily' into the productive process, and its mate, shop-floor culture, encourages an accommodation to, rather than a rejection of, the *fundamental* social relations there.

Something in the spirit of betrayal implicit in this kind of powerful and intensive, but formally limited, cultural organization is often caught in the semi-mythical, apocryphal, cultural folk wisdom of the shop floor. The following is an explanation of why young lads want to go on the shop floor given to me by a middle-aged worker in an engineering factory.

I was thirteen, like, an impressionable age, I s'pose, and this is something I've never forgotten. I was with my old man and we were at the zoo, and we saw a crowd up on the 'ill like, people were clapping, and all crowding around a gorilla's cage. We pushed to the front, like, Dad was more curious than me, like, he got right to the front, and there was this gorilla clapping and stamping, and lookin' around like, havin' a good time. All the people were clapping, egging him on like. Then he suddenly come to the front of the cage and spat a mouthful of water all over our old man. He'd been goin' to the back of the cage, like, gettin' a mouthful of water, comin' forward, clapping like, then spitting the water out all over 'em.

My old man stood back really shocked like . . . then he went back in the crowd and waited for some other silly buggers to push forward. I didn't realize then, like, I was only a kid, what it meant like . . . , but I do now. We don't all grow up at once, see, that's life, we don't grow up at the same time, and when you've learnt it's too late. It's the same with these kids comin' in

the factory, every time, they think its great. 'Oh, what's this, I wanna be there', y'know what I mean. You'll never change it, it's the same with everything, comin' to work, getting married, anything—you name it.

There is a fairly clear theory here about what makes kids want to start work, as well as a long-suffering, half-amused, typical working-class fatalism. There is also the ironic dynamic of the morality play. What is most noticeable, however, is a naturalized sense of timelessness: 'life's like that'. It's nobody's fault, nobody's failure, that makes the gorilla spit, or shop-floor life kill with monotony, or the wife nag to an early grave. It's simply the grim reality that humans have *always* faced. The same principle of the treacherous appearance disguising—and leading to an entrapment in—the real situation below is common to many aspects of working-class culture, and particularly in people's attitudes to the main transitions of life: birth, death, marriage, retirement, religious conversion. Even sometimes, it seems, death will turn out not to have been worth the trouble, though of course, the compelling unity of the drama means that the full ritual of the funeral cortege, plus cars bigger than ever were ridden in during life, must be gone through. We may suggest, however, that this final powerlessness before nature might be less of a universal law, and more a product of a specific, historic and continuing failure of working-class culture to achieve a basic modification of the conditions which brought it in to being. For all its symbolic resistance, the moving spirit of working-class culture till the present has been accommodation to a pre-given reality, rather than an active attempt to change it.

The reasons for this basic limitation stretch right back to the history of the world's first industrial proletariat and we cannot go into them now, but two contemporary factors might be mentioned specifically in relation to shop-floor culture. The trade union is the institutional extension of the culture of the work-place, the form in which culture and its meanings might have become more visible and the vehicle through which really concrete attempts have been made to transform *symbolic* into *real* control.

Trade unions, however, can be seen in their modern function merely as a mediation between shop-floor culture and the dominant managerial culture. Unionism negotiates the space between them and, in this negotiation, gives up much that is really central to the shop floor for what is often simply an accommodation in managerial interests. The nature of unionism and

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its organization is not, however, evenly textured. While the union bosses adopt a form of managerial culture and join the main industrial establishment,¹⁴ the shop stewards and local organizers are still very much of the local culture. While trying to achieve union and organizational aims, they use specifically cultural forms of communication—spectacle, bluffs, drama, jokes, sabotage, to mobilize the man.¹⁵ The union structure, then, is a complex and varied institution which strikes different degrees of appeasement at its various levels. The power of shop-floor culture determines at least the *form* of union activity at plant level, but the higher administrative level has completely lost that detailed binding-in with the lived culture of the work-place which was the original guarantee of true representativeness. To put it another way, the unions have lost touch with, even betrayed, the real roots of working-class radicalism—the culture of the shop floor.

From the side of capital, one of the most important controls on the power of shop-floor culture to challenge its own conditions is the practice of management science and human relations. Under the banner of a 'neutral' humanization of the work process, it has been one of the most formidable techniques of social control ever developed. Essentially, human relations rest on a simple and obvious discovery: informal groups exist. This is precisely, of course, the area covered by the culture of the shop floor. Hard on the discovery of this territory came techniques for colonizing it. Techniques of 'employee-centred supervision', 'consultation', 'open door relations' can neutralize oppositional shop-floor culture on its own grounds by claiming the informal group for management ideology. This can unbend its springs of action. The sense of control given to the workers by these techniques is usually illusory—the basic structures of power remain—and yet the located, rich, potentially dominating culture of resistance is being destroyed.

Whatever the final balance-sheet drawn of strengths and weaknesses in shop-floor and working-class cultures,¹⁶ the point of this article has been to stress the continuity of school culture with the wider class culture, and to draw attention to the deep-moving processes of regeneration among this class—some of the most important of which occur at the site of the school. These processes should not be mistaken, in the sociology of education, for mere institutional flux or localized disturbance. What is *not supposed* to go on in school may have more significance for us than what is *supposed* to go on in school.

Wayward Lives, Beautiful Experiments, ft Saidiya Hartman

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Alejo: I’m Alejo Stark and you’re listening to Rustbelt Abolition Radio, an abolitionist media and movement building project based in Detroit, Michigan. Today we have the extraordinary opportunity to speak with Saidiya Hartman, professor of English and Comparative Literature at Columbia University and author of three books: “Scenes of Subjection: Terror, Slavery, and Self-Making in 19th Century America”, “Lose Your Mother: A Journey Along the Atlantic Slave Route”, and the recently released “Wayward Lives, Beautiful Experiments: Intimate Histories of Social Upheaval”. Welcome and thank you for joining us Saidiya.

Saidiya Hartman: Thank you for having me. It’s great to be here.

Alejo: So we wanted to start by asking you about your recently published book, “Wayward Lives, Beautiful Experiments”. Your writing, it seems to me — in particular the fragments from the book that you shared with us yesterday at your talk — inhabit the problematic of the long continuum between the plantation, the ghetto and the prison, which is to say, the anti-blackness that constitutes political antagonisms to this day. But in these fragments, you also laid bare the beauty, autonomy, anarchy, fugitivity, queerness and erreny in forms of black sociality and what you called a black woman’s intimate revolution in the early 20th century. “Waywardness”, as it were. Can you tell us how you encountered the sense of waywardness, what it’s meant by it?

Saidiya Hartman: In thinking about the period in the aftermath of not only slavery, but in the aftermath of the failure of reconstruction, I really wanted to think about the ways people tried to enact a practice of freedom on the ground and a freedom in the space of this new racialized enclosure which was coming into being, and that shift from the plantation to the ghetto as an open air prison. And so what’s also taking place is that these practices of freedom — in some ways the only way to articulate that practice is through the sheer ability to move; unregulated movement and the rush to the next place, that one hope is better than the place you’re in — articulated what’s also so striking for me about this period between 1890 and 1935 and the way in which these practices come to be criminalized.

Saidiya Hartman: So, the classic instruments used against the propertyless, like vagrancy laws are used to criminalize forms of noncompliance. The refusal to work becomes criminalized and all of these become essential elements of building this formation that is the ghetto. I think I was so amazed and taken by how consistent and multiple the forms of resistance were. The forms of refusal to that targeting, the refusal to be trained and regulated for poorly paid labor that couldn’t ensure the most minimal forms of social reproduction. And so what we see is young women and others

forming these collective living situations where people work minimally but pool their resources, or just the desire to have a beautiful life, the desire to try to make a beautiful life. I mean, I think that for me, what I'm looking at are the very quotidian and daily practices through which people try to refuse the anti-blackness that is the normative condition, and one motive that refusal is: what does it mean to love what is not loved? All right. I think I've always been interested in everyday — the practice of the multitude, the mass, the ensemble — and the, I would say: the revolutionary spirit that resides there. Trying to narrate an account of that collective activity, that collective longing and dreaming.

Alejo: Could you perhaps share with us a fragment of this collective, ensemble, multitude, this anarchic fugitive force and these everyday acts of refusal, as you mentioned?

Saidiya Hartman: Yes, I'll read a snippet from it. While there's the kind of the open air prison, which is the ghetto, I think what's also interesting about this period, even in this early period, we see the continuities between the prison and the ghetto. And I guess the book takes for granted — so it's not a book about the “the emergence” of the prison — but it just takes for granted the carceral landscape in which black life unfolds. So I'll read from a chapter called “Riot and Refrain”.

Saidiya Hartman: It was the dangerous music of open rebellion. En masse they announced what had been endured, what they wanted, what they intended to destroy. Bawling, screaming, cursing, and stomping made the cottage tremble and corralled them together into one large, pulsing formation, an ensemble reveling in the beauty of the strike. Young women hung out of the windows, crowded at the doors, and huddled on shared beds sounded a complete revolution, a break with the given, an undoing and remaking of values, which called property and law and social order into crisis. They sought *out of here, out of now, out of the cell, out of the hold*. The call and the appeal transformed them from prisoners into strikers, from faceless abstractions secured by a string of numbers affixed to a cotton jumper into a collective body, a riotous gathering, even if only for thirteen hours. In the discordant assembly, they found a hearing in one another.

The *black noise* emanating from Lowell Cottage expressed their rage and their longing. It made manifest the latent rebellion simmering beneath the surface of things. It provided the language in which “they lamented their lot and what they called the injustice of their keepers at the top of their voices.” Sonic upheaval was a tactic, a creative resource of the riot, in December and January, and again in July, when a clash erupted in the laundry room between a group of mostly black girls, including their white friends and lovers, and a group of white girls who hated the nigger lovers as much as they hated the black girls. When the police and state troopers arrived, the battle shifted and the girls fought them. The state authorities and the journalists were eager to label the clash as a race riot, but even so, they described the sound of the struggle against the state in the terms of black music. To those outside the circle it was a din without melody or center. The *New York Times* had trouble deciding which among the sensational headlines it should use for the article, so it went with three: “Devil's Chorus Sung By Girl Rioters.” “Bedford Hears Mingled Shrieks and Squeals, Suggesting Inferno Set to Jaz(z).” “Outbreak Purely Vocal.” What exactly did Dante's Inferno sound like when transposed into a jazz suite? For the reporters, jazz was a synonym for primal sound, unrestrained impulse, savage modernism. It was raw energy and excitement, nonsense and jargon, empty talk, excess, carnal desire. It was slang for copulation and conjured social disorder and free love. Perhaps this was an oblique reference to the sexual dimension of the riot. Improvisation—the aesthetic possibilities that resided in the unforeseen, collaboration in the space of enclosure, the secondary rhythms of social life capable of creating an opening where there was none—exceeded the interpretive grid of the state authorities and the journalists.

Sonic tumult and upheaval—it was resistance as music. It was a noise strike. In the most basic sense, the sounds emanating from Lowell were the free music of those in captivity, the abolition philosophy expressed within the circle, the shout and speech song of struggle. If freedom and mutual creation characterized the music, it too defined the strike and riot waged by the prisoners of Lowell. “The Reformatory Blues,” a facile label coined by the daily papers to describe the collective refusal of prison conditions, was Dante filtered through Ma Rainey and Buddy Bolden. (The sonic upheaval of Lowell Cottage echoed and sampled the long history of black sound—whoops and hollers, shrieks and squawks, sorrow songs and blues.)

The chants and cries escaped the confines of the prison even if their bodies did not: “Almost every window [of the cottage] was crowded with negro women who were shouting, crying and laughing hysterically.” Few outside the circle understood the deep sources of this hue and cry. The aesthetic inheritance of “jargon and nonsense” was nothing if not a philosophy of freedom that reached back to slave songs and circle dances—the sonic gifts of struggle and flight, death and refusal, became music or moanin’ or joyful noise or discordant sound.

For those within this circle, every groan and cry, curse and shout insisted slavery time was over. They were tired of being abused and confined; they wanted to be free. Aaron had written almost those exact words in one of his letters: “I tell you Miss Cobb, it is no slave time with colored people now.” So had Mattie’s mother. All of them might well have shouted, *No slave time now. Abolition now. In the surreal, utopian nonsense of it all*, and at the heart of riot, was the anarchy of colored girls: treason *en masse*, tumult, gathering together, the mutual collaboration required to confront the prison authorities and the police, the willingness to lose oneself and become something greater—a chorus, swarm, ensemble, mutual aid society. In lieu of an explanation or an appeal, they shouted and screamed. How else were they to express the longing to be free? How else were they to make plain their refusal to be governed? It was the soundtrack to a history that hurt.

Alejo: Thank you for sharing that with us. These sort of fragments, what you called “excavating the beauty of a wrong turn” beyond, of course, this logic of the fall and repentance which saturates a lot of the narratives that we hear from those that are being held captive by the state inside prisons and jails and detention centers, the logic of recognition and so on... You’ve traced these errant paths, these riotous gatherings and the kinds of life also that are maybe lived in our freedom, right?

Alejo: One of the questions that we always grapple with in the show is: we feature narratives and communiques from comrades and those being held captive by the state today and these words, their words — in a way their sounds, their written word and their spoken word — attempt to register precisely those practices of freedom today, as well; that interrupt the state’s apparatus of capture. But nonetheless, they also perhaps circulate within an anti-black libidinal economy of pain and suffering, but also pleasure. And this gives us pause, right? So you have grappled with this question of course as it relates to the historical archives which subvert in these narratives, and for us as abolitionist media makers, we grapple with this sort of infinite responsibility of attempting to interrupt the state’s narrative while also not putting in circulation these sounds and words within this anti-black libidinal economy. So we know you grapple this question again and again in your writing. Can you tell us more about this and what might it entail to think about an abolitionist ethic, an abolitionist aesthetic — how you’ve dealt with this in your own form, in writing as well.

Saidiya Hartman: Yeah, that’s a great question. I mean, I think that from Scenes, where I question what does it mean to mobilize the black body in pain for white liberal abolitionist cause; you know, the reproductive labor that they’re forced to perform. I mean, I think that here, when

we look at this state archive of prison records, we're talking about the advent of the progressive state, and these liberal reformers who are literally the children of those great white abolitionists. So I think the terms of address are really key, so that it's not a politics that's translated through a framework of recognition. If I make claims in this way, if I can explain the case to the state in this way, then perhaps I will get a hearing. I mean, I think that the paradox of this violence is that it is the kind of the plan and the instrument of progressive reformers who are trying to protect and "care" for these girls.

Saidiya Hartman: I think that there's a struggle around the most fundamental terms of life in order. And I think one of the ways I think about this everyday anarchy is thinking about the radical practices of subsistence. So how do people make a way when their wage labor doesn't actually require them to kind of reproduce the minimal conditions of social existence. So in that formula, there's certain things that are facts, like rent is a fact. And so why is rent a fact? Why is it a fact to charge the propertyless for shelter? Because we're so — in a liberal spectrum, at least — we're taking for granted the rightness of property. Right? And I think that what happens with these young women — and it is only registered as criminality, as irresponsibility, just the kind of contestation around all of those organized terms of social existence. Well, why is one required to labor in this way when even liberal legal reformers understand domestic work to be a form of involuntary servitude? I mean, liberal legal thinkers are talking about it as a kind of feudalism. So why wouldn't they refuse it?

Saidiya Hartman: I kind of think about this as a continuation of the general strike. I mean, one of the things that Rosa Luxemburg says in the mass strike, which I love, is that a strike can go on for decades, right? And I think that... that strike against a plantation as not only about the flight from the south and the plantation, but the refusal of those conditions and everyone is trying to say, "No, this is the responsible path. This is what is there for you in the world and your responsibility is to be the dutiful poor", right? "And to demonstrate your worthiness for a certain kind of second-class citizenship". And their actions and their thoughts in every way are saying "no" to that project. The consequences of that "no" are great, and the price that they're forced to pay for that refusal are great, but they're astute social analysts. They know that there's no future in that.

Alejo: Just to go back to this question of the state's own facts — the refusal also of those facts — that "no" which is also an act of freedom. You mentioned the general strike and Du Bois, the chapter on "The coming of the Lord," not tipping your hat and not being afraid of the patrol, of being able to go and fish — these sort of everyday acts of the practices of freedom as it were, which in a way interrupt and disrupt the state's own apparatus of capture. This trespassing between fact and fiction I think is how we think about it. For us, this sort of maybe even critical fabulation also comes into play in how we construct narratives from the narratives that people that are held captive today tell us from prison, right? We face the state's own narratives about, for instance, the prison strike: that "nothing happened," you know, and we sometimes find ourselves in a situation of not being able to communicate as we would like. And so there's perhaps some need to create a story about what happened with those from inside, to conspire with them. So I would like to think about that, the ethics of that, and the political stakes of that today. What we're thinking about as an "abolitionist ethic" or you know, even the form in which we express these narratives which are always mediated, right? As much as we simply just record somebody's voice inside. How have you grappled with this question of form? Certainly you've changed in a way, you know, from *Scenes of Subjection* to *Wayward Lives*, the form of your writing, which also in a way expresses a certain ethic and aesthetic as well.

Saidiya Hartman: I mean I would just firstly echo what you say about the state's interest in disappearing these forms of struggle and making them non-events. I mean in the case of this strike in Lowell, prison authorities would always be — and even though they were called reformatories, they are prisons in essence — they were very troubled if a journalist actually used the name of one of the prisoners because again, it was to give a kind of an embodiment and an individuality and a particularity to the faceless abstraction that the state tries to produce.

Saidiya Hartman: I mean, I think that one of the differences here is I see all of these projects, I mean I see *Wayward Lives* as a continuation of *Scenes*. I think that in *Scenes*, one of the things that I was kind of really arguing with was a certain kind of liberal social history of slavery and a very limited notion of what slavery was as a kind of unwaged work with cruelty, to thinking about social death and fungible life and the lasting imprint of that in the definition of anti blackness and how foundational anti-blackness is to this democratic “state project”.

Saidiya Hartman: I think here I'm narrating from what has been this longstanding space of black study and that's the formation of the circle. And we see that whether it's bodies assembled in the hold door, the circle formation that Douglas describes or the clearing made by fugitives and how they inhabit the landscape and that there is an address we have with and for one another. And so I think that this book is narrated from that space. And I guess it's an encouragement really to think about the proliferation of practices and thinking about how we take up questions of survival in a multitude of ways.

Saidiya Hartman: I guess one of the other people who's in this, someone like James C. Scott, who has written a lot about another kind of anarchy looking at peasants in South Asia and the way they try to exist at the edge of and outside of large state forms. Someone asked me about the relationship between this project and *Lose Your Mother* because I think that, you know the last chapter of that book is called *Fugitive Dreams*, and it's about all of those new social formations that emerge as people were fleeing from predatory state forms. I mean those state forms were African, but they were nonetheless predatory state forms that created disposable lives to be involved in this transatlantic network of exchange. And I think that for me, the space of the chorus is also about the mutual aid society. What we do in the meantime, how we provide for one another.

Saidiya Hartman: And I think it's trying to turn our attention away from certain modes of political address which are dominant, which seemed to be: always the need to explain to the same people the forms of violence and predation that make our lives just disposable with no movement. And I think that those forms of address actually underestimate the deep, deep social and psychic investment in anti-blackness as a definition of the human in this context. So it's about turning my attention to a space where it seems really possible to imagine an elsewhere and to try to mobilize other political imaginaries.

Alejo: Well with that I just wanted to thank you for enacting precisely those other imaginaries of the possible, as you say, to the many possible abolitionist futures that I think are maybe already here in many ways.

Saidiya Hartman: Thank you for having me on.